

SHORTCUT TO BABUDOM

Wannabe civil servants among junior Bihar officials take the road oft travelled to realise their dreams and BPSC only paves the way

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

Arun Kumar Sinha, a clerk at Vaishali collectorate, had enough reasons to be smitten by the white Ambassador car with a yellow beacon that his boss had been using. Equally obsessed was Kalanand Singh, an assistant with the Bihar director-general of police. They got an opportunity to enter the coveted league during the Rabri Devi government when the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) held the first "Limited Competitive Examination" in 2003 for junior officials to qualify as civil servants. But they were looking for a shortcut and, like many others, got it rather easily.

Sometimes even the best laid plans can go awry. This perhaps best explains the spectacular fall from grace for the 184 Class III government officials—who were once within striking distance of donning the deputy collector's hat in Bihar after the BPSC declared them successful in May 2005—and now face a vigilance charge-sheet. What, however, put their aspirations on hold was the dissolution of the Bihar assembly on May 23, 2005. The one controversial decision of the Union Cabinet to put the state under the President's rule—put to effect only three days after the declaration of BPSC results—left Bihar in a political whirlpool with nobody having even a minute to spare for these wannabes. This indeed proved costly because once

voted to power and briefed by the aggrieved parties about the serious discrepancies in BPSC results, Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on December 7, 2005 ordered the Bihar Vigilance Bureau to dig deep into the mess, besides putting the training and posting issues on hold. On May 13 this year, the bureau recommended scrapping of the examination results. So far, it has chargesheeted 92 out of the 184 selected candidates besides 11 BPSC officials. The Patna High Court—which was first approached by the affected junior government officials from the 4,000 who appeared for the examination—is now monitoring the investigations. The next date of hearing is July 2.

To begin with, BPSC was found to have set two question papers having only objective type questions, though as per rules one of them had to be subjective. This, according to the sleuths, helped them manipulate the results. The locks of the BPSC strongroom—where the answersheets were kept—were found to have been tampered with. "The copies were brought out and redone by the favourite candidates," says Neelmani, additional director-general of Bihar Vigilance Bureau. "Besides, BPSC officials declared the optical measurement scanner—that reads the answersheets of objective type questions—to be inoperational. The reason cited was crashing of the computer database. Manual



"The middleman arranged loans for applicants and the money was used for bribing officials."

NEELMANI | ADDITIONAL DIRECTOR-GENERAL, BIHAR VIGILANCE BUREAU

